

This is actually one of the most common first-time home buyer questions. A buyer's agent makes money by earning a commission of 2.5 to 3 percent of the property's purchase price. It's usually included in the seller's closing costs—meaning that you, the buyer, don't directly pay your agent. Of course, refer to your offer contract or ask your agent to confirm this.

Should I get multiple home inspections to be safe?

Nope. Just make sure to hire a great inspector the first time around. The only time you should pursue extra inspections is when you need something not included with your typical home inspection (like a radon test, sewer scope, mold test, etc.)

When am I allowed to back out of a contract and still keep my earnest money?

This depends on the “contingencies” section of your contract. Typically, the buyer is allowed to back out of a deal for four main reasons: the mortgage loan was not approved, problems came up with the home inspection, the appraised value of the home came in lower than the purchase price, or something fishy came up on the title. Again, check your contract or ask your agent for any clarification.

If my earnest money is late, will I lose everything?

Technically, you can fall out of contract if you miss any of your deadlines. Best to make sure your earnest money gets into the hands of the title company before it's due. However, you wouldn't be asking this question if it weren't already a problem—so make sure to talk to your agent about the specifics of your contract. If the money is one or two days late, the seller *might* let it slide without causing a fuss. (They don't want to fall out of contract either.)

I paid more in earnest money than the actual final closing costs. Do I get my money back?

First of all, you should celebrate your tiny victory! It's not the worst feeling in the world to get some money *back* when you buy a house. The answer here is yes—the title company is not allowed to keep your leftovers. They